

FROM BESTSELLING AUTHOR

priest



STARS OF CHAOS:
SHA PO LANG VOL. 1

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*From the swaying
tips of duckweed,
fierce winds arise*



PROLOGUE

Chapter 1: Borderlands

IN THE SMALL BORDER TOWN of Yanhui, there was a hill known as General's Slope. Despite its majestic name, it was, in reality, nothing more than a small mound of earth. Those with long necks could easily see over its crest.

General's Slope hadn't always existed. Fourteen years ago, the Black Iron Battalion, the number one armored cavalry of Great Liang, had embarked on the Northern Expedition and laid waste to the Eighteen Barbarian Tribes. It was said that as they passed through Yanhui Town on their march back to the capital, the victorious troops cast aside their battered armor and created this mound. After many years of being swept by sand and dust and battered by wind and rain, General's Slope took form.

General's Slope was barren. No matter what seeds one sowed here, nothing would grow. Even weeds refused to thrive, and consequently, there wasn't even any brush behind which those who wished to carry on clandestine love affairs might hide. Such a bald patch of dirt was completely useless. The old folks of the town all agreed the place was cursed—the murderous crimes committed by the Black Iron Battalion were so severe that malevolent energy had accumulated and overwhelmed this bit of earth. In time, some idle troublemakers cooked up a whole series of chilling ghost stories about the borderlands based on their words. Thus, by and by, people stopped going there.

The sky was already darkening, yet two ten-year-old kids had run out to the base of General's Slope.

One was tall and thin, while the other was short and round. Paired together, the two of them looked like a bowl and chopsticks hurtling along.

The tall, thin one was dressed like a girl, and only upon closer inspection did it become clear that he was, in fact, a boy. He was called Cao Niangzi. When he was very young, a fortune-teller declared that he had been destined to be born a girl. Since he had been reincarnated into the wrong body, there was a chance the heavens might recall his soul and recast him in a form that matched his destiny. Fearing he would die young, his family named him “Lady” and raised him as a girl.

The short, round one was the youngest son of Butcher Ge. He was called

Ge Pangxiao and, living up to his name of “Little Porker,” his skin was coated in a faint but rich sheen of oil.

The two of them craned their necks and peered over at General’s Slope. Recalling those hair-raising tales, neither of them dared draw any closer.

Ge Pangxiao held a copper-plated field scope up to his eye. Straining his neck, he looked intently at General’s Slope. “The sun’s already set, but he still hasn’t come down from the hill. My dage¹ is really...what’s the word—slamming the books hard!”

“It’s ‘hitting the books hard’—but enough nonsense,” Cao Niangzi said. “Hurry up and hand over that scope.”

This sham of a girl played his role almost too well. It was just a pity that the way he played it left something to be desired. He was nothing like a well-bred young lady; rather, he resembled nothing so much as a coarse shrew with a distinct fondness for pinching people with those chicken claws of his. Every time he extended his crooked fingers, Ge Pangxiao’s flabby flesh would begin aching dully in anticipation of an attack. He hurried to obediently offer the field scope to the other boy. “Be careful with that,” he warned. “My dad’ll beat me into mincemeat if we break it.”

The so-called “field scope” was a small hollow cylinder made of copper. It was engraved with an image of five bats² and fitted with a crystal-clear disc of glass on the inside. Looking through this scope, one could determine the sex of a rabbit from over ten kilometers away. Ge Pangxiao’s field scope was of unusually fine make, having been left to him by his grandfather, a former military scout.

Cao Niangzi held it reverently in his hands for a long while before lifting it skyward to look up at the stars. “It’s so clear.”

Ge Pangxiao looked up as well and pointed. “I know that one. That’s the evening star. It’s also called ‘Changgeng,’—the same as my dage. Shengxiansheng³ taught it to us before.”

“Who are you calling your dage?” Cao Niangzi’s lip curled. “As if he pays you any mind. You’re always following him around, sucking up to him and insisting he’s your dage. Honestly, it’s embarrassing... Hey, wait. Isn’t that him over there?”

Following Cao Niangzi’s pointing finger, Ge Pangxiao saw the person he’d been waiting for.

A youth with a sword in his hand and his head bowed was slowly making his way down General's Slope. Suddenly it was as though Ge Pangxiao no longer feared the ghosts. He burst forth like a ball of lightning, hollering, "Dage! Dage!"

In his haste, he tripped at the bottom of General's Slope and somersaulted into a heap, coming to a stop at the youth's feet. Ge Pangxiao lifted his grimy face, not even bothering to push himself up as he revealed a silly, flattering smile. The smile became a grimace as he said, "Hee hee, Dage, I've been waiting for you all day."

The youth named Chang Geng silently withdrew his foot from where he had nearly trodden on Ge Pangxiao.

Whenever Chang Geng saw Ge Pangxiao, he felt a little amazed. Butcher Ge, who had slaughtered so many thousands of pigs, must have been born with a pair of eagle eyes. How else to explain how the man had managed to avoid butchering his own son for so many years? But Chang Geng had a steady nature and was unfailingly courteous. He kept his thoughts to himself; he would never say something so unkind out loud.

In a manner quite becoming of an older brother, Chang Geng helped Ge Pangxiao to his feet. "Why are you running?" he asked, dusting the younger boy off. "Be careful you don't fall and hurt yourself. Were you looking for me?"

"Chang Geng-dage, your dad's coming back with the others tomorrow. We don't have class either, so why don't we go goose-feed snatching together? We could beat the snot out of that little monkey Li and the rest of his gang!"

Chang Geng's father was Company Commander Xu, but the two shared no blood relation.

At the age of two or three, Chang Geng had followed his widowed mother Xiu-niang⁴ to the border to seek refuge with relatives, only for the pair to find themselves stranded—said relatives had moved away long ago. It just so happened that Company Commander Xu, the commanding officer of the troops stationed in Yanhui Town, was a widower whose wife had died young and left him no children. He took a fancy to Xiu-niang, and soon took her as his second wife.

Company Commander Xu was presently leading a contingent of soldiers beyond the border to collect the barbarians' annual tribute. Reckoning the days since he'd set out, he ought to be returning within a day or two.

Life on the border was simple and poor, and the children here rarely enjoyed luxuries like snacks. Whenever the soldiers marched out to collect tribute, they picked up some of the barbarians' dried meats and cheese along the way, which they would then toss into the crowds waiting by the roadside upon their return. This was the phenomenon known as "goose-feed snatching," wherein street urchins scrambled to fight each other for food like geese for scraps of bread. With all the kids grabbing for prizes at once, it was practically inevitable that the crowd would come to blows. As long as no one got seriously hurt, the adults turned a blind eye, allowing the children to band together and gang up on each other as they pleased.

All the kids in town knew this: when it came time for goose-feed snatching, whoever won Chang Geng's allegiance was guaranteed a certain victory.

Ever since he began learning martial arts as a child, Chang Geng had been meticulous in his practice. Countless military families lived along the border, so there were plenty of children who studied martial arts. But practicing martial arts was a grueling process, so most kids only ever casually dabbled, their sloppy efforts yielding unexceptional results. Chang Geng was the only one who had climbed General's Slope daily to train alone since the day he picked up the sword. His years of diligent practice were a testament to his extraordinary determination.

Chang Geng had yet to turn fourteen, yet he could already lift a sword weighing over thirty kilograms with one hand. He was well aware of his capabilities and never took part in the other kids' scuffles. Nevertheless, the other children were all inexplicably a bit scared of him.

Chang Geng brushed aside Ge Pangxiao's proposal with a smile. "I'm way too old to be chasing after goose feed."

Ge Pangxiao refused to back down. "I already talked to Shen-xiansheng, and he agreed to give us the next few days off!"

Chang Geng walked slowly with his hands behind his back, the heavy sword bumping against his leg with every stride. Ge Pangxiao's words were childish, and he ignored them. It was his decision whether to study or train with his sword—it didn't matter whether their tutor gave them a day off or not.

"Besides," continued Ge Pangxiao, "Shen-xiansheng said he needs to change Uncle Shiliu's medications, and he might have to head out of town to purchase medicinal herbs, so he won't be home anyway. You won't have

anywhere to go, so you might as well come with us. Don't you get bored training all day?"

These words finally caught Chang Geng's attention. He stopped walking and turned to Ge Pangxiao. "Didn't Shiliu just get back from Changyang Pass? How did he get sick again?"

"Uh...that's what I heard. But then again, he never really gets better, does he?"

"Well, in that case, I'm gonna go check on him." Chang Geng waved at his two little tag-alongs and said, "Hurry home; it's so late already. Your dad'll beat you if you hold up dinner."

"Ah, Dage. About the..."

Chang Geng had no interest in listening to him prattle on. The difference of a single year meant a lot to boys this age when it came to size and maturity. Chang Geng was already beginning to find it difficult to play with little kids like Ge Pangxiao. With his longer stride and taller stature, he left the two younger boys behind in the blink of an eye.

Ge Pangxiao's plan to win Chang Geng as an ally was a failure; the plump boy had wasted his time. He sighed in disappointment and turned back to glare at Cao Niangzi.

"Why didn't you say anything?!"

Cao Niangzi's cheeks were bright red, his gaze drifting. All his bossiness from a moment ago had completely evaporated. Clutching at his chest like a love-struck maiden, he said, "Even when he's just walking, my Chang Geng-dage really does look more handsome than anyone else."

Speechless, Ge Pangxiao decided at that moment that he would never go out with this embarrassing loser ever again.

The Shen-xiansheng and Uncle Shiliu of whom Ge Pangxiao spoke were a pair of brothers who shared a somewhat special relationship with Chang Geng.

Two years ago, when Chang Geng was not yet so grown up, he'd snuck out of the city gate by himself to play. In the wilderness outside town, he'd gotten lost, and was quickly surrounded by a pack of wolves that would have dragged him away had the Shen brothers not luckily passed close by. The pair saved his life, driving away the starving wolves using the medicinal powder they carried. To thank them for saving Chang Geng's life, Company Commander Xu leased the brothers one of his empty courtyards free of charge, and the two